THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Prelim

One step on each page: a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. The last room trains your ears.

THE ROOMS

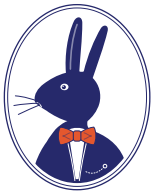
1 · Practising well
2 · Loud and soft
3 · The staff and the keyboard
4 · Reading the notes
5 · How long is a note?
6 · Time signatures
7 · Repeats
8 · Touch: smooth and short
9 · Major scales
10 · Minor scales
11 · Chords and triads
12 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Practising well

SCAN TO LISTEN

1	2	3
Slow	Small	Correct



Good practice is **slow**, **small** and **correct**.

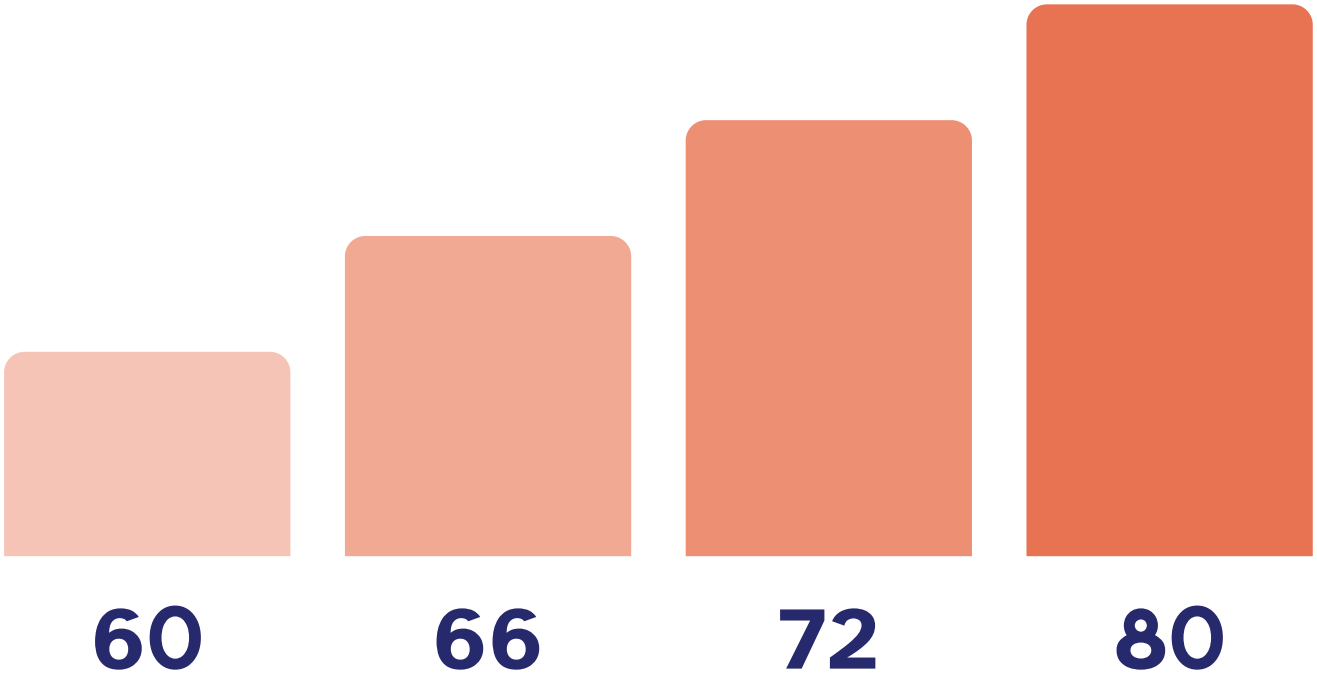
Slow enough to get it right. A small piece at a time. And right from the very first try.

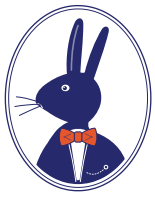
Try it at the piano

1. Choose two bars of your piece. Play them at half speed, with no wrong notes. ○

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

Practising well





When it is right **three times** in a row, go **one step faster**.

If it falls apart, step back down. This is the metronome ladder.

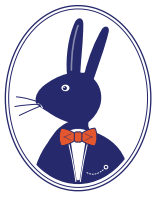
Try it at the piano

1. Set a metronome (a ticking beat-keeper; there is one in the app) to 60. Play your two bars three times. All right? Move up to 66. ○

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

Practising well

1	2	3	4



Every piece has a **hardest bar**. Find it and practise it **first**, while your mind is fresh.

Then join it to the bar before and the bar after.

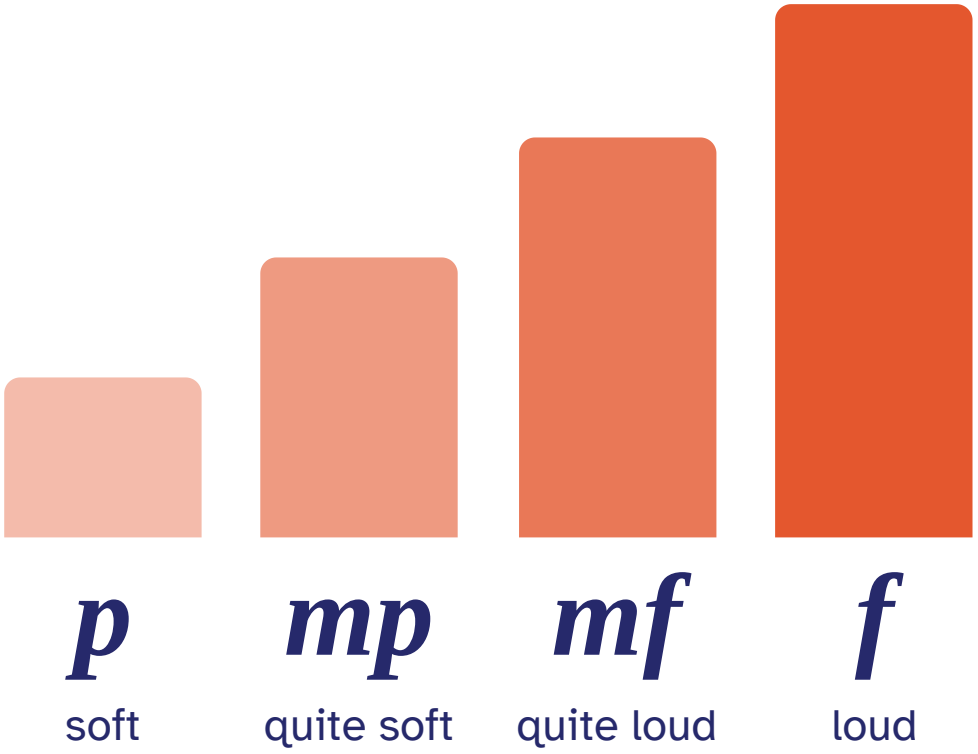
Try it at the piano

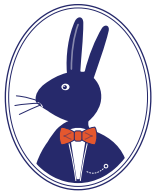
1. Find the hardest bar in your piece. Play it slowly five times, then play it with its neighbours. ○

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN





Four signs tell you how loud to play. ***p*** is *piano*, soft. ***f*** is *forte*, loud.

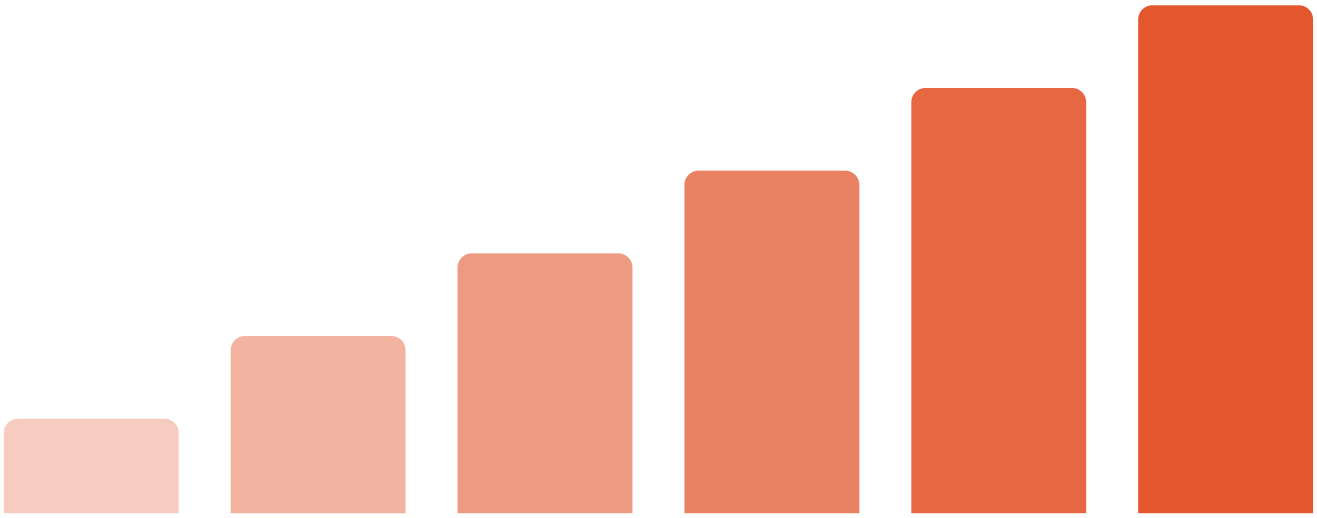
Mezzo means medium: ***mp***, mezzo piano, is quite soft and ***mf***, mezzo forte, is quite loud.

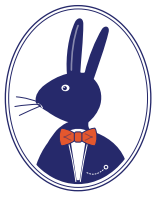
Try it at the piano

1 Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

Loud and soft





Two letters mean **very**: ***pp*** is very soft, ***ff*** is very loud.

That makes six steps, from a whisper to a shout.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C six times, one step louder each time. Then come back down the steps. ○

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

Loud and soft



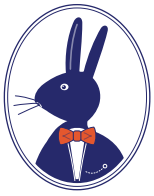
crescendo

getting louder



diminuendo

getting softer



A sign that **opens** means get louder little by little: **crescendo**. A sign that **closes** means get softer: **diminuendo**.

The wide end is the loud end.

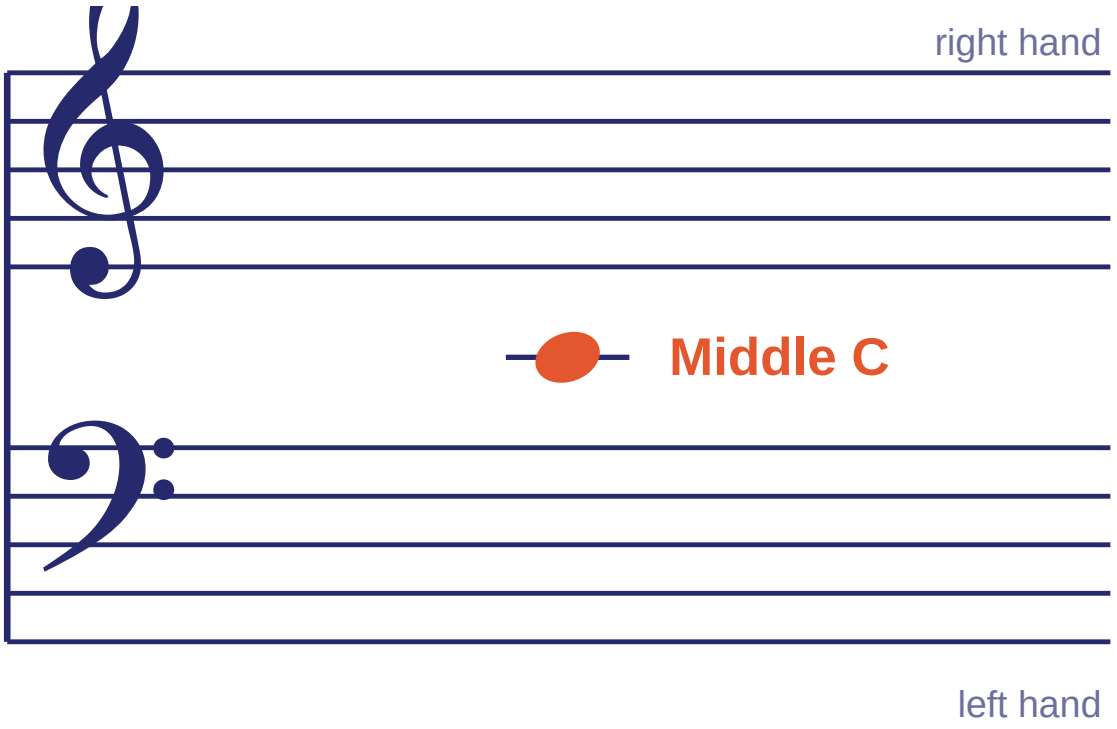
Try it at the piano

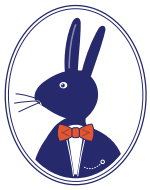
1 Play C D E F G getting louder, then G F E D C getting softer.

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

The staff and the keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN





Piano music uses **two staves** joined together: the top one for the right hand, the bottom one for the left.

The curly sign at the top is the **treble clef**. The one below is the **bass clef**.

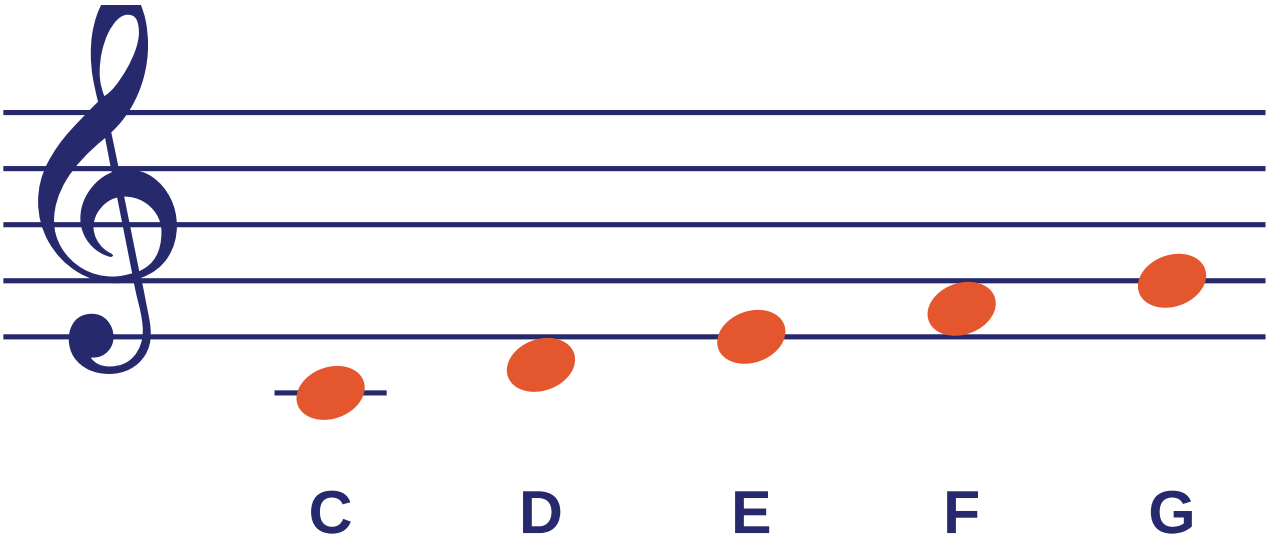
Middle C sits between them, on a little line of its own.

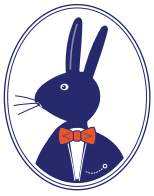
Try it at the piano

1. Find Middle C: the C nearest the middle of your piano. Play it with each thumb.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

The staff and the keyboard





From Middle C, each **step up** on the staff, line to space, space to line, is the **next white key** to the right.

Line, space, line, space, line: C, D, E, F, G.

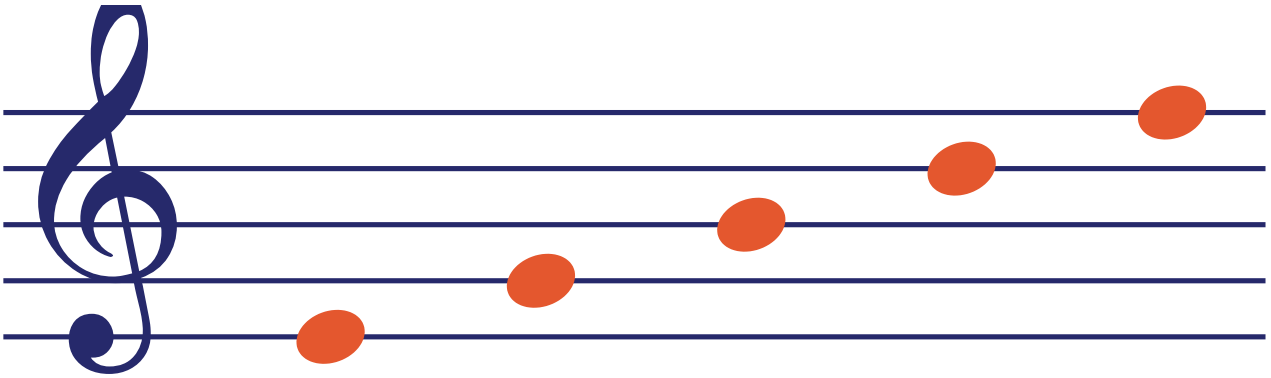
Try it at the piano

1. Right thumb on Middle C. Play C D E F G while you look at the five notes on the staff. ○

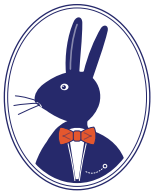
ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 3

Reading the notes

SCAN TO LISTEN



E G B D F



The five **lines** of the treble staff are **E G B D F**, from the bottom up.

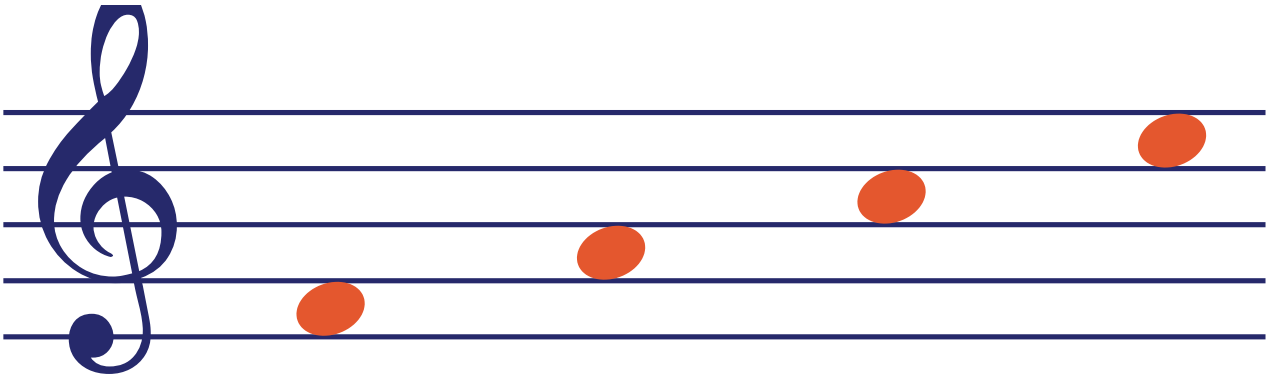
A sentence helps: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**eserves **F**un.

Try it at the piano

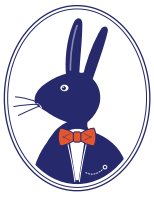
1. Play E G B D F going up from the E above Middle C, saying the sentence.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 3

Reading the notes



F A C E



The four **spaces** of the treble staff spell a word: **F A C E**.

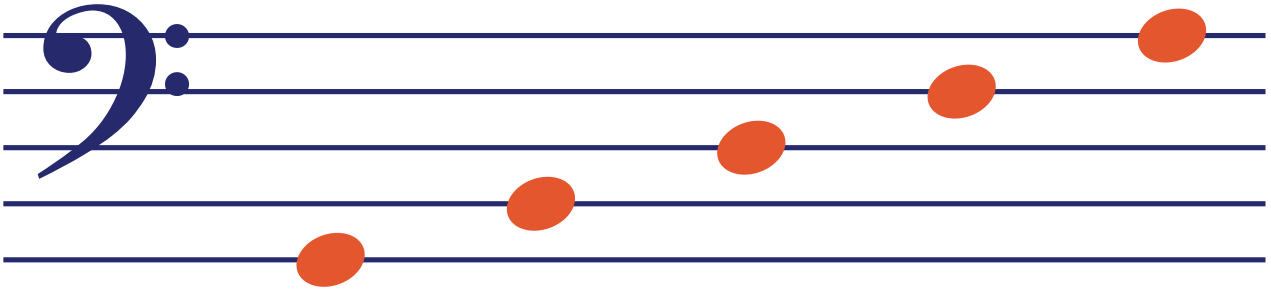
Lines and spaces take turns, so the notes go F, G, A, B, C, D, E.

Try it at the piano

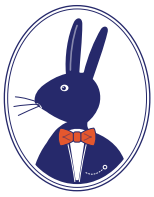
1. Play F A C E going up. Then play F G A and say which is a space and which is a line.

ROOM 4 · STEP 3 OF 3

Reading the notes



G B D F A



The bass staff has its own names. Its **lines** are **G B D F A**: **G**reat **B**ig **D**ragons **F**ly **A**way.

Its spaces are **A C E G**: **A**ll **C**ows **E**at **G**rass.

Try it at the piano

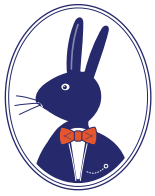
1. With your left hand, play G B D F A going up from the second G below Middle C, saying the sentence.

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 7

How long is a note?

SCAN TO LISTEN





One circle is **one beat**. A **crotchet** is one circle. A **minim** is two, a **dotted minim** three and a **semibreve** four.

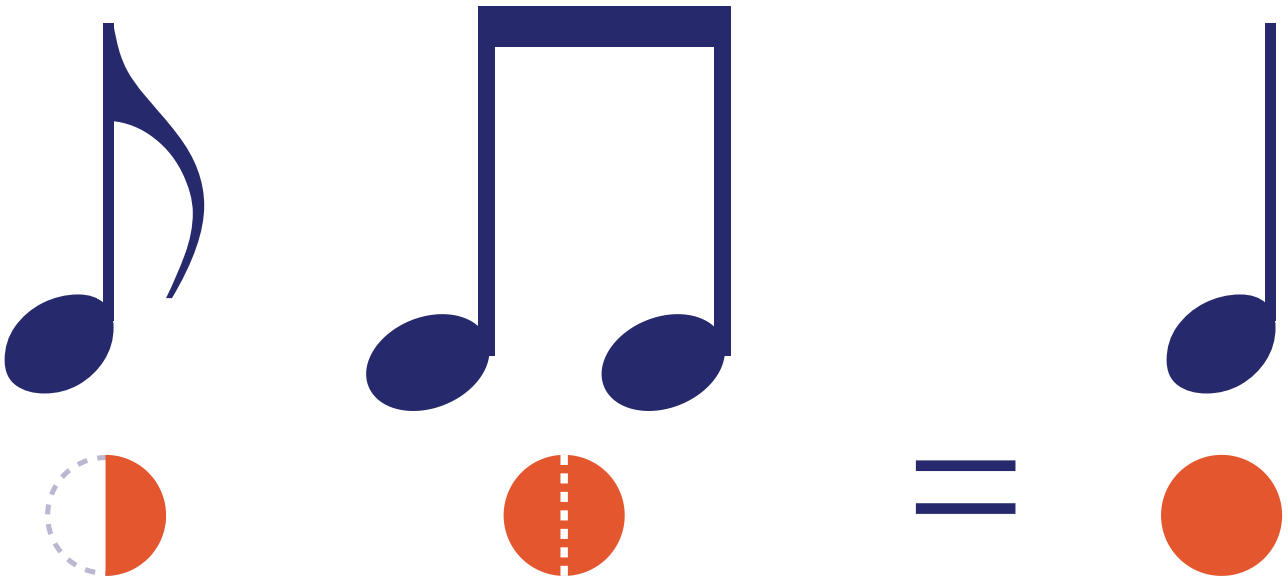
Now come the notes shorter than one beat: pieces of the circle.

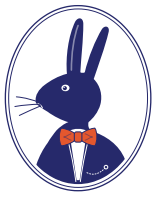
Try it at the piano

1 Play C as a semibreve, a dotted minim, a minim and a crotchet, counting the beats out loud: 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 7

How long is a note?





Cut the circle in half. A **quaver** is **half a beat**, and on its own it has a **tail**.

Put two halves together and you have one whole beat: two quavers joined by a **beam**. We count them **1 and**.

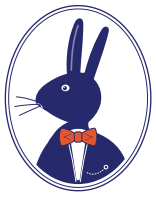
Try it at the piano

1 Play C in crotchets, counting 1 2 3 4. Then in quavers, counting 1 and 2 and 3 and 4 and.

ROOM 5 · STEP 3 OF 7

How long is a note?





Cut the circle in four. A **semiquaver** is a **quarter of a beat**, and on its own it has **two tails**.

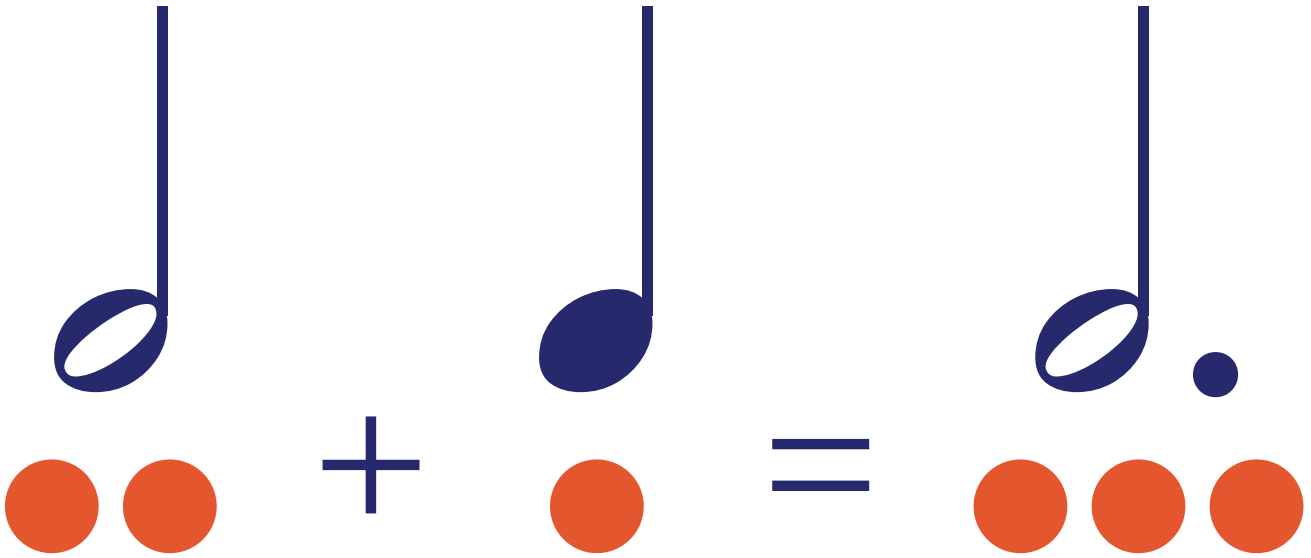
Put four quarters together and you have one whole beat: four semiquavers joined by **two beams**. Say **wa-ter-me-lon**.

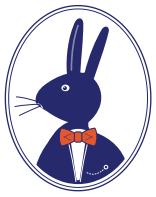
Try it at the piano

1 Clap four beats. Then tap four semiquavers on every beat, saying wa-ter-me-lon.

ROOM 5 · STEP 4 OF 7

How long is a note?





A **dot after a note** makes it longer: it adds **half** of the note again. That is why a dotted minim has one more beat.

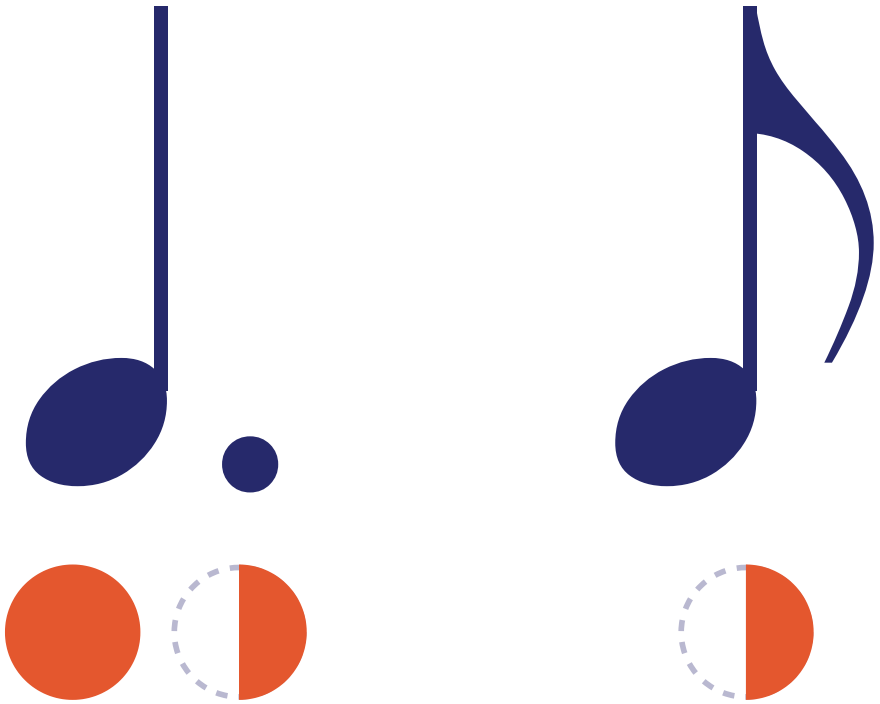
A minim is 2 beats. Half of 2 is 1. So a dotted minim is 2 + 1 = **3 beats**.

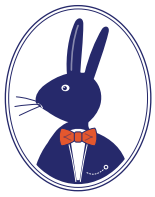
Try it at the piano

1. Play C as a minim, counting 1 2. Then as a dotted minim, counting 1 2 3.

ROOM 5 · STEP 5 OF 7

How long is a note?





A dot after a crotchet adds half a beat: a **dotted crotchet** is **one beat and a half**.

A quaver usually follows it to finish the second beat. Long, then short: **1 – 2 and**.

Try it at the piano

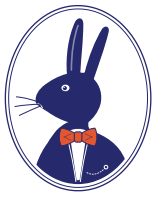
1. Play C long, then D short, counting 1 – 2 and. The D comes on the “and”.

ROOM 5 · STEP 6 OF 7

How long is a note?



2 + 1 = 3 beats



A **tie** is a curved line joining two notes that are the **same**. Play the first one and **hold** through the second.

A minim tied to a crotchet lasts three beats.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C and hold it for 1 2 3. You have played two notes with one press.

ROOM 5 · STEP 7 OF 7

How long is a note?



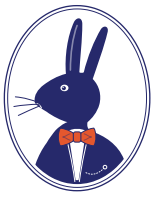
1 beat



2 beats



4 beats



A **rest** is a sign for **silence**. You count it just like a note, but you do not play.

The crotchet rest lasts 1 beat. The minim rest sits on a line for 2. The semibreve rest hangs under a line for 4.

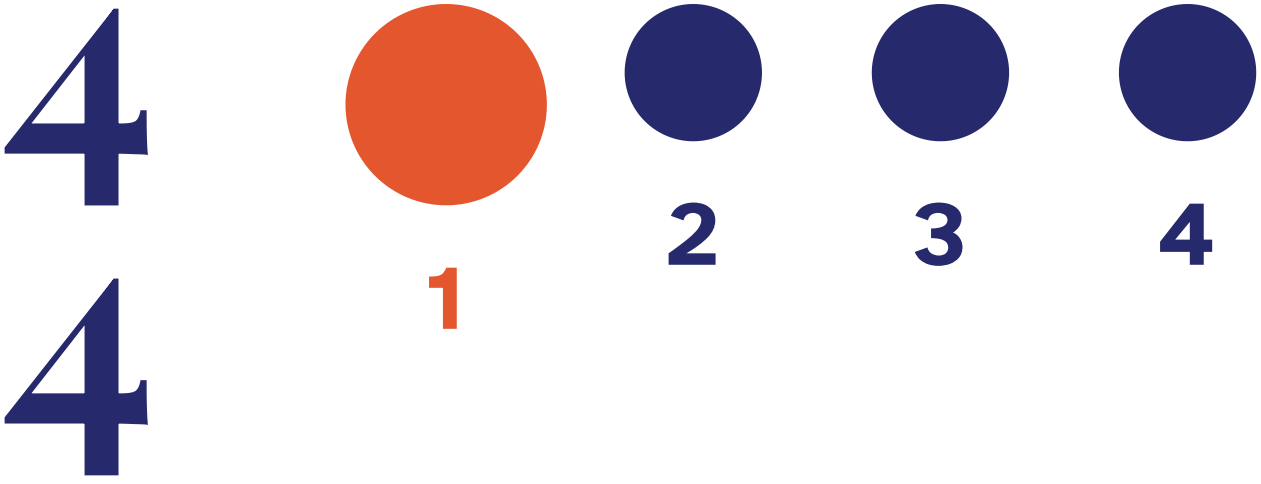
Try it at the piano

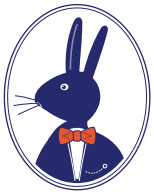
1. Play C, C, then lift your hand for one beat, then C: 1, 2, (rest), 4. Keep counting through the silence.

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

Time signatures

SCAN TO LISTEN





The two numbers at the start are the **time signature**.

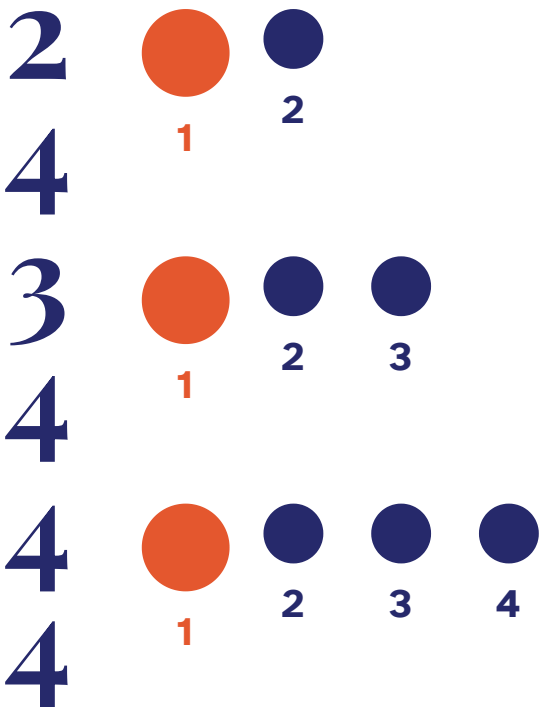
The **top number** says how many beats are in every bar. The bottom 4 says each beat is a crotchet.

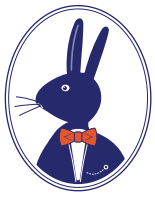
Try it at the piano

1. Clap four beats in a bar, the first one stronger: ONE two three four.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3

Time signatures





Two in a bar marches: left, right. **Three** in a bar swings round, like a waltz. **Four** in a bar walks along: 1 2 3 4.

Beat 1 is always the strongest.

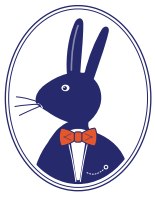
Try it at the piano

1. Clap each one: ONE two · ONE two three · ONE two three four. Which does your piece use?

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3

Time signatures

1	2	3
Andante	**Moderato**	**Allegro**
at a walk	not slow, not fast	quick and lively



A word above the first bar tells you **how fast** the beat goes. The words are Italian.

Andante is a walking speed. **Moderato** is in the middle. **Allegro** is quick and lively.

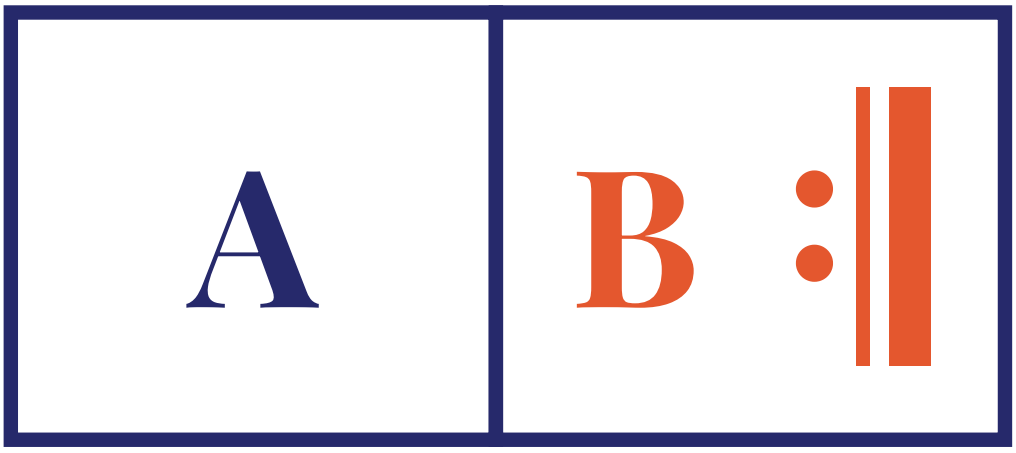
Try it at the piano

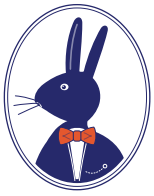
1. Clap four beats Andante, then Moderato, then Allegro. Find the speed word at the top of your piece.

ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 2

Repeats

SCAN TO LISTEN





Two dots beside a double bar line make a **repeat sign**. It means: **go back and play it again**.

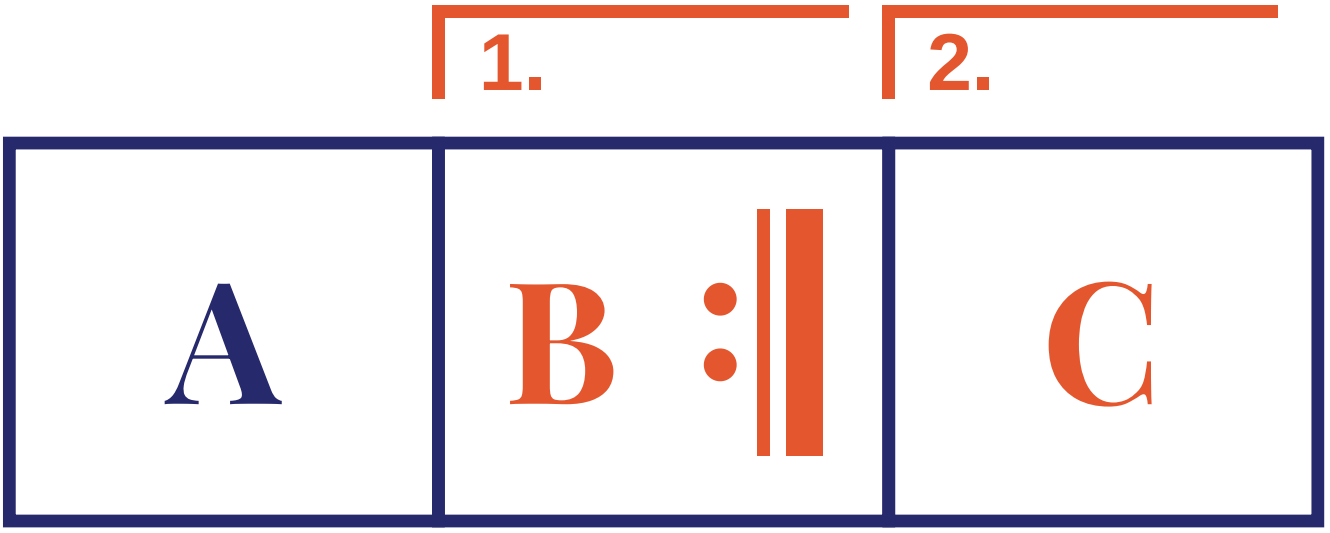
So this music is played A B, then A B once more.

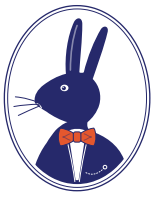
Try it at the piano

1. Find a repeat sign in your book. Play up to it, then go back to the start and play it again.

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 2

Repeats





A repeat can have two endings. The bar marked **1** is played the first time only.

The second time, **skip it** and jump to the bar marked **2**: A B, then A C.

Try it at the piano

1. Say the order out loud for this picture: A, B, back, A, C. Then look for a first-time bar in your music.

ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

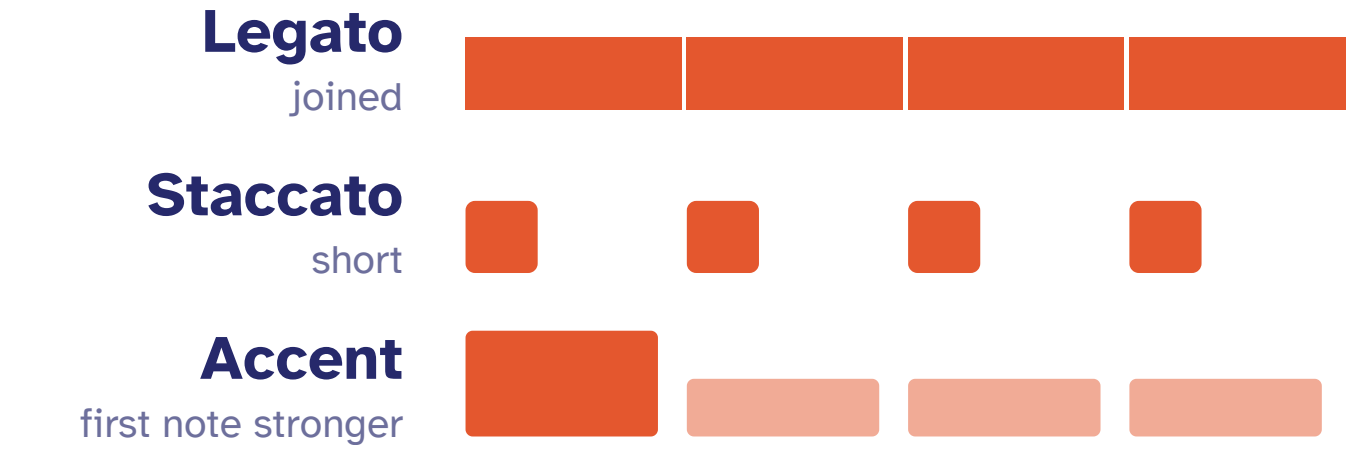
Touch: smooth and short

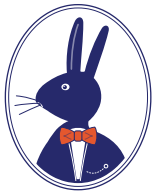
SCAN TO LISTEN

Legato
joined

Staccato
short

Accent
first note stronger





The same notes can be played in different ways. **Legato** means smooth and joined. **Staccato**, a dot above or below the note head, means short.

An **accent** (>) means that note is stronger. Remember: a dot *after* a note makes it longer, a dot *under* it makes it short.

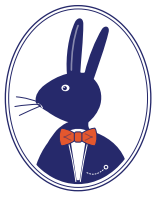
Try it at the piano

1. Play C D E F G smoothly, each finger passing the sound to the next. Then play it staccato, like hot keys.

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Touch: smooth and short





A curved line over **different** notes is a **slur**. Play them smoothly, in one breath, and lift gently at the end.

A tie joins the same note; a slur joins different ones.

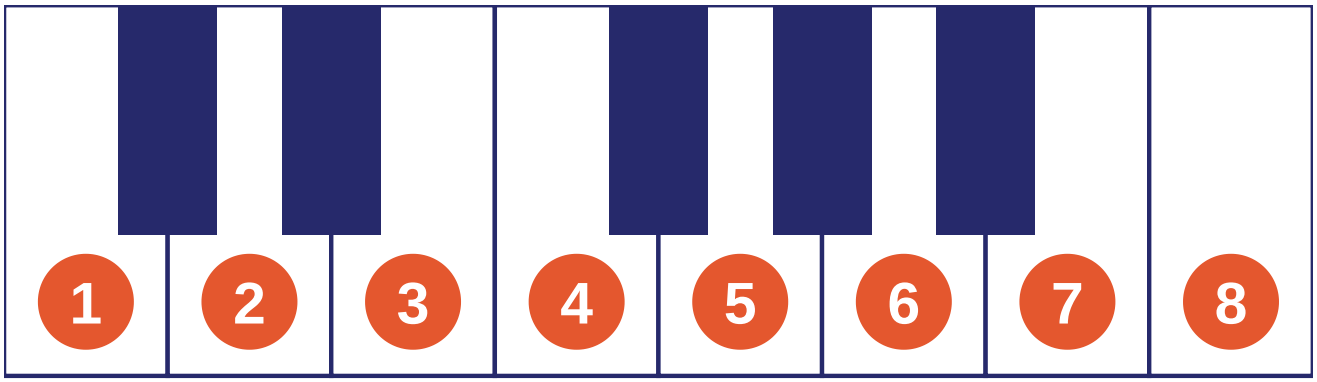
Try it at the piano

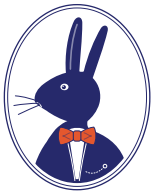
1. Play C D E F as one slur: sink into the C, float off the F.

ROOM 9 · STEP 1 OF 4

Major scales

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **scale** is a ladder of eight notes. Play the white keys from C to the next C and you have **C major**.

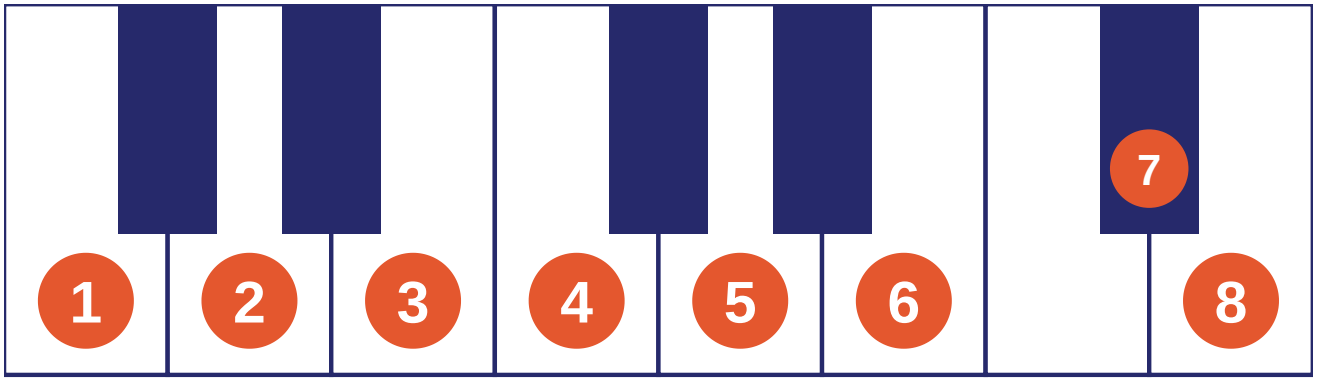
Notes **3–4** and **7–8** are close together, with no black key between. Every other pair has a black key between.

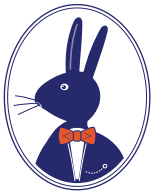
Try it at the piano

1 Play C major going up with one finger, saying the numbers 1 to 8. Listen for the two close steps. (Which fingers? That comes two pages on.)

ROOM 9 · STEP 2 OF 4

Major scales





G major starts the same ladder on G. One note has to change: the 7th becomes **F sharp**, so that 7–8 stay close.

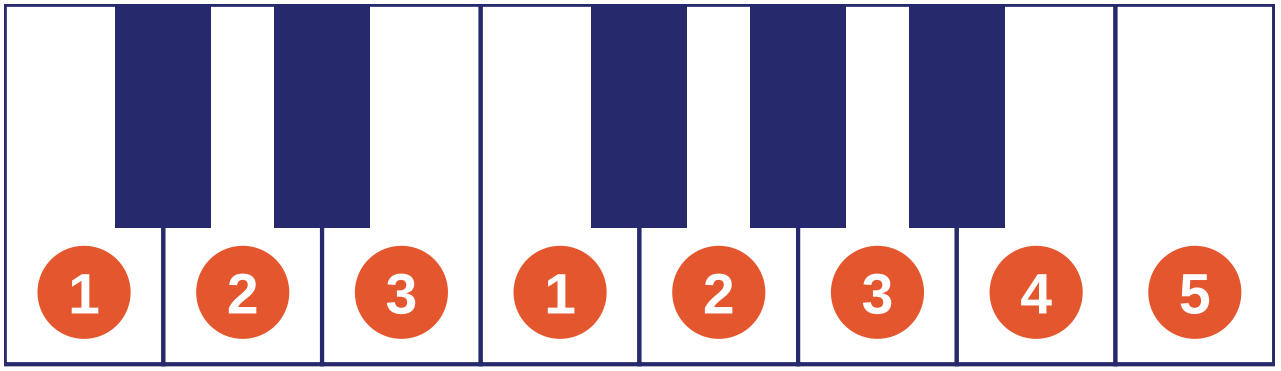
A **sharp** (♯) is the very next key to the right, here a black one. G major has one sharp, F♯.

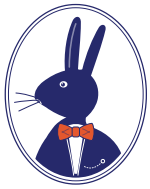
Try it at the piano

1. Play G A B C D E, then the black key F♯, then G. Now try it with a white F: hear how it sounds wrong.

ROOM 9 · STEP 3 OF 4

Major scales





Eight notes, five fingers. Going up, the right hand plays **1 2 3**, then the **thumb tucks under** and plays **1 2 3 4 5**.

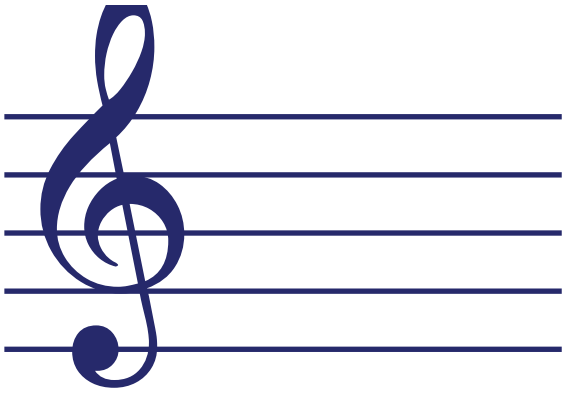
From one C to the next is one **octave**. Coming down, play 5 4 3 2 1, then finger 3 crosses over: 3 2 1. The same fingers work for G major, A minor and E minor.

Try it at the piano

1 Right hand, C major, one octave up and down, slowly. Say the finger numbers. Left hand going up: 5 4 3 2 1, then finger 3 crosses over: 3 2 1.
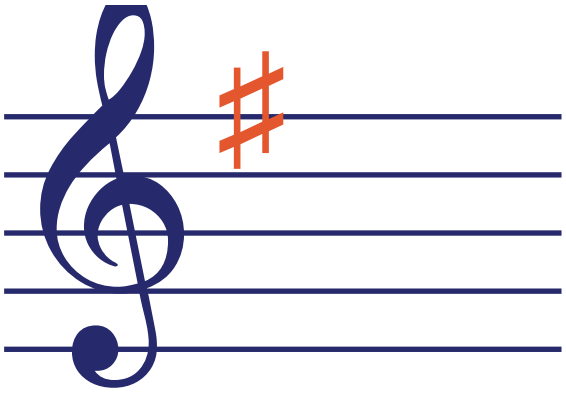
ROOM 9 · STEP 4 OF 4

Major scales



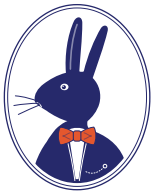
C major

no sharps



G major

one sharp: F♯



The sharps printed right after the clef are the **key signature**. They tell you which notes are sharp all the way through.

No sharps: C major. One sharp, on the F line: G major. Every F is then played as F♯.

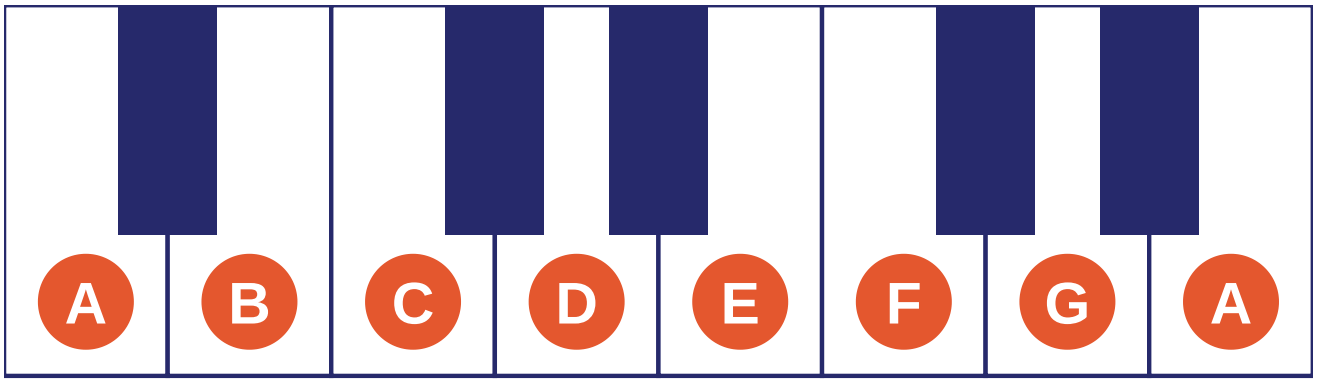
Try it at the piano

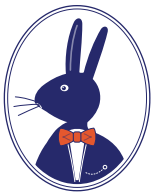
1. Look at the start of your piece. How many sharps are after the clef? ○

ROOM 10 · STEP 1 OF 3

Minor scales

SCAN TO LISTEN





Play the white keys from A to A and you have **A minor**. It uses the same notes as C major, so its key signature has no sharps. But A is home, and it sounds darker.

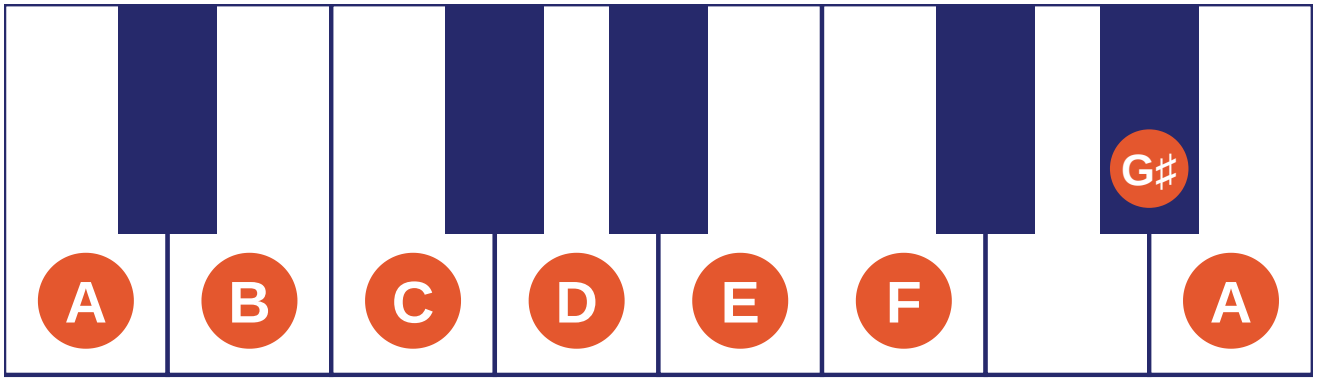
This plain form is the **natural minor**.

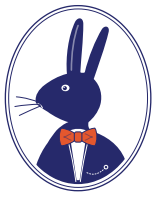
Try it at the piano

1 Play C major up and down, then A natural minor. Same white notes, a different mood.

ROOM 10 · STEP 2 OF 3

Minor scales





Raise the 7th note one key, G to **G sharp**, and the scale pulls strongly back home.

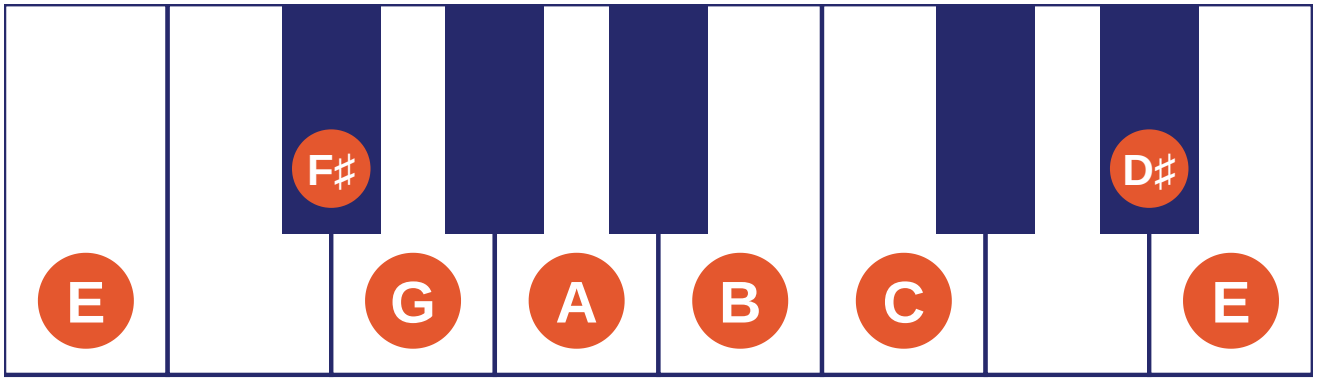
This is the **harmonic minor**: A B C D E F G♯ A.

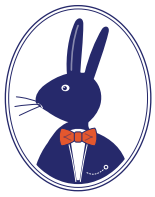
Try it at the piano

1. Play A harmonic minor slowly. Stop on G♯ and feel how much it wants to go up to A. ○

ROOM 10 · STEP 3 OF 3

Minor scales





E minor uses the same notes as G major, so it keeps **F sharp** and the same key signature. E is home.

For the harmonic minor, raise its 7th note too: D becomes **D sharp**.

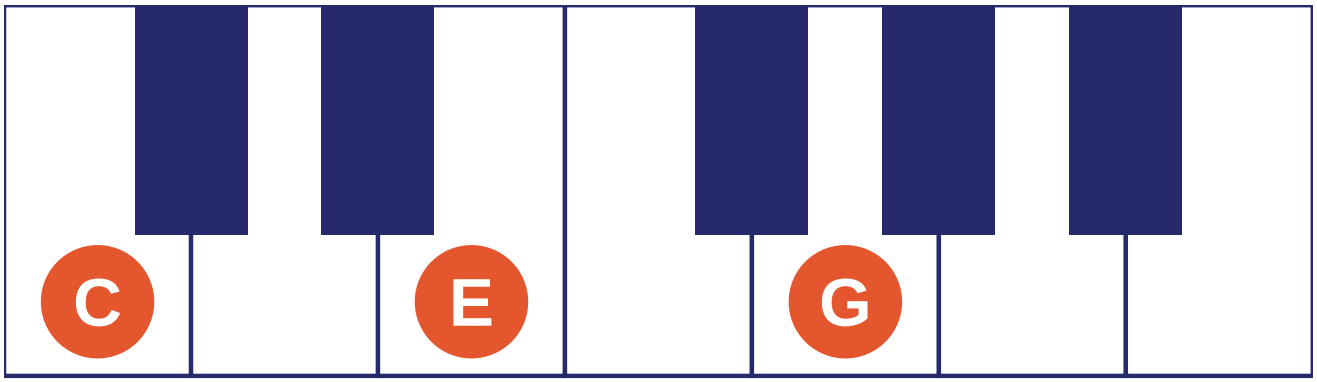
Try it at the piano

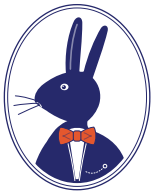
1. Play E natural minor (with F♯), then E harmonic minor (F♯ and D♯).

ROOM 11 · STEP 1 OF 2

Chords and triads

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **chord** is notes played together. The simplest full chord is a **triad**: three notes.

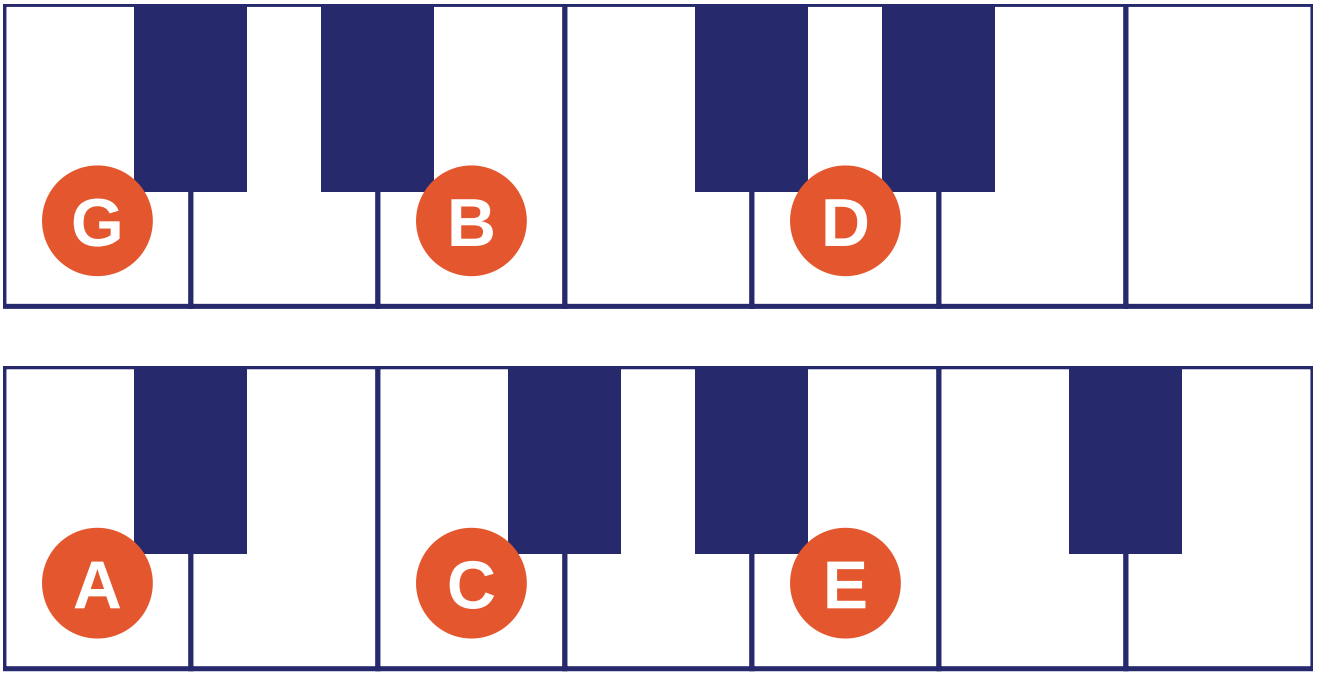
To build one: **play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one**. C, E, G.

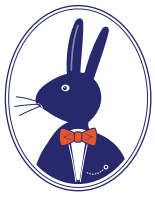
Try it at the piano

1 Right hand fingers 1, 3 and 5 on C, E and G. Play them one at a time, then all together.

ROOM 11 · STEP 2 OF 2

Chords and triads





The triad shape works on other white keys too. On G it gives **G B D**. On A it gives **A C E**.

The bottom note names the triad. C and G sound bright: **major**. A sounds darker: **minor**.

Try it at the piano

1. Keep your hand in the triad shape and move it: C E G, then G B D, then A C E.

ROOM 12 · LISTEN

Ear training

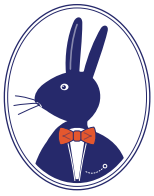
SCAN TO PLAY

1 **Clap the beat**

2 **Echo the rhythm**

3 **Sing the tune**

4 **Higher or lower?**



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Four listening games belong to this level. Each one is in the app: scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1 Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?